Soviet rift, which erupted into open clash in 1969 over the border dispute regarding the number of islands located in the Ussuri River.

The bipolar world of the Cold War was becoming tripolar. The worsening of relation of China with the Soviet Union led the United States to take leverage of the Sino–Soviet split. Nixon and Kissinger played the China card well. USA took the initiative to recognize Mao's regime as the rightful government of China in early 1971. USA also sent a US table-tennis team to China, dubbed as a ping-pong diplomacy, which was well-acknowledged by the Chinese. In July 1971, Kissinger's secret visit to China, followed by Nixon's tour, only six months later surely showed the US intentions of playing China against the Soviet Union. Therefore, the US fostered good relations with both the communists giants, and more precisely, towards the Soviet Union using the policy of 'carrot' and 'stick'.

Brandt's Ostpolitik: The German Chancellor, Willy Brandt's *Ostpolitik* was largely responsible for easing of tensions between the two superpowers. Bonn initially tried to extend relations with the countries of Eastern Europe but that got a jolt with the Soviet invasion on Czechoslovakia in 1968. Bonn realized that without Moscow's support this could not be achieved. Therefore, improvement of relations with Moscow became a priority. On 12 August 1970, Soviet Union entered into a non-aggression treaty with West Germany. This agreement with the Soviet Union laid the foundation for similar agreements with Poland and East Germany. Even Brandt acceded to the Oder–Neisse line as Polish frontier and this was designed to propagate the spirit of *Ostpolitik*. This normalized relations not only between West Germany and Soviet Union but also between the Eastern and the Western blocs. Thus, Summits between the East and the West became common.

Linkage Theory: The chief architects of détente, Richard Nixon and Henry Kissinger, envisaged the easing of tensions on the basis of **linkage strategy**. This aimed at binding the two rivals in a common fate by making peaceful superpower relations dependent on the continuation of mutually rewarding exchanges (such as trade concessions), thereby lessening the incentives for conflict and war.